

Not By Bullets Alone



Make no mistake. India is at war, every day. Last week Palaniappan Chidambaram told Parliament, "For many years we did not assess the Left Wing extremism challenge correctly. I think we underestimated the challenge." The Home Minister couldn't have been more forthright. Every year since 2005, India has been witness to an average of 1,500 incidents of Naxal violence, resulting in the death of over 750 people. Translated, that is five incidents of Naxal violence every day and 60 killings every month. For many in urban metros it might seem like a war in another India, but truth be told this fire is now raging across 160 districts—that is nearly one in four districts. Quite naturally there is a move to ramp up the scale of anti-Naxal operations, Chidambaram wants to raise 26,000 men for the battle ahead. No democracy can allow violence to dictate the agenda.

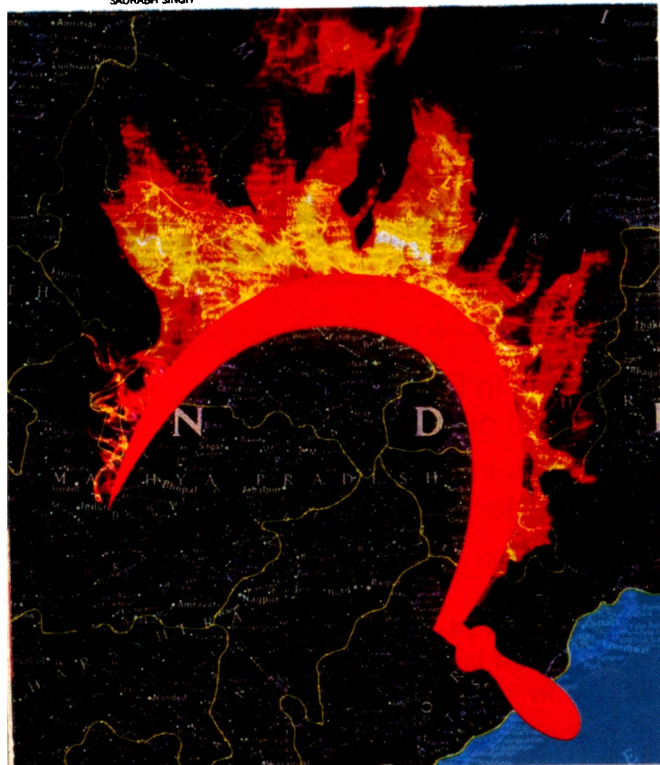
It is a war that the state must win and mandates use of force. Force has always been an integral part of statecraft. Force has a logic that is instantly seductive. Force also has the potential of influencing change. But force alone may not be enough, it needs other catalysts. It is not enough to shoot the Naxal; we have to kill the thought and the conditions that nurture Naxalism. Each of the 80 worst-affected districts on the clichéd "sickle corridor" is a live monument to the failure of governance. No schools, poor health care, exploitative feudalism, no jobs, pathetic social infrastructure. It is a formula for brewing Naxalism. Worse, there is no escape. Over three lakh villages have no road connectivity. Take Dantewada in Chhattisgarh. It boasts of 30 per cent literacy and is on the 100 worst districts list for the past two decades. If Naxalism has to be extinguished then the state must ask why it blooms where it blooms? Yes, there is some attempt but it's thin and diluted.

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India spends Rs 80,000 crore a year on myriad poverty alleviation schemes. Why not focus all the schemes and maybe add more moolah muscle to the 80 worst-affected districts? Why not get senior administrators, even retired ones, to man the districts for five years? Pump all the money meant for rural roads into the districts, micro focus rural dole NREGA, introduce mobile schools, create a mini-grid to deliver power to these districts and get corporates to focus their social responsibility efforts into these districts.

This war is not, and should not be only about killing Naxalism. It should be about delivering on genuine internal security. It is about ridding ourselves of the shame that our people live in such appalling conditions. It is about being true to the idea of India.

SAURABH SINGH



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Vocalist **D.K. Pattammal**, 90, who along with M.S. Subbulakshmi and M.L. Vasanthakumari,



formed the 'female trinity' of Carnatic music. She recorded over 50 albums and sang in over 50 films.

WON: By **Deepika Kumari**, the gold medal in the cadet recurve women's event at the 11th Youth World Archery Championship at Utah, US.

DIED: **Chennas Raman Namboodiripad**, 77, head priest of the Guruvayur Sreekrishna temple in Thrissur.

NAMED: Former badminton champion **Pullela Gopichand** as one of the recipients of the Dronacharya award 2009 for coaching. With this, he becomes the only Indian to have been conferred with all of the country's major sports awards, the other two being the Arjuna Award and the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna.

